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Islamic State of Iraq and the Levant

The **Islamic State of Iraq and the Levant** (**ISIL**; /ˈaɪsəl, ˈaɪsɪl/), also known as the **Islamic State of Iraq and Syria** (**ISIS**; /ˈaɪsɪs/),[85] officially known as the **Islamic State** (**IS**) and also known by its Arabic-language acronym **Daesh** (Arabic: داعش, romanized: *Dāʿish*, IPA: [ˈdaːʕɪʃ]),[86][87] is a terrorist militant group and a former unrecognised proto-state[88] that follows a fundamentalist, Salafi jihadist doctrine of Sunni Islam.[89][90] ISIL gained global prominence in early 2014 when it drove Iraqi government forces out of key cities in its Western Iraq offensive,[91] followed by its capture of Mosul[92] and the Sinjar massacre.[93]

The group has been designated a terrorist organisation by the United Nations as well as by many international organisations and individual countries. ISIL is widely known for its videos of beheadings and other types of executions[94] of both soldiers and civilians, including journalists and aid workers, and its destruction of cultural heritage sites.[95] The United Nations holds ISIL responsible for committing human rights abuses, genocide, war crimes, and crimes against humanity.[96] ISIL also committed ethnic cleansing on a historic and unprecedented scale in northern Iraq.[97]

ISIL originated as *Jama'at al-Tawhid wal-Jihad* in 1999, which pledged allegiance to al-Qaeda and participated in the Iraqi insurgency following the 2003 invasion of Iraq by Western forces at the behest of the United States. In June 2014, the group proclaimed itself a worldwide caliphate[98][99] and began referring to itself as the Islamic State (الدولة الإسلامية *ad-Dawlah al-Islāmiyah*; IS).[100] As a caliphate, it claimed religious, political, and military authority over all Muslims

Islamic State of Iraq and the Levant	
الدولة الإسلامية في العراق والشام *ad-Dawlah al-Islāmiyah fī 'l-ʿIrāq wa-sh-Shām* Participant in the Iraq War (2003–2011), the Iraqi insurgency, the Syrian Civil War, the Iraqi Civil War, the Second Libyan Civil War, the Boko Haram insurgency, the War in North-West Pakistan, the War in Afghanistan, the Yemeni Civil War, and other conflicts	
Primary target of Operation Inherent Resolve and of the military intervention against ISIL in Syria, Iraq, Libya, and Nigeria	
 The Black Standard used by ISIL[1]	 The seal of ISIL[2][3][4]
Active	**1999–present** ▪ Established under the name of Jama'at al-Tawhid wal-Jihad: 1999 ▪ Joined al-Qaeda: October 2004 ▪ Declaration of an Islamic state in Iraq: 13 October 2006 ▪ Claim of territory in the Levant: 8 April 2013 ▪ Separated from al-Qaeda:[5][6] 3 February 2014[7] ▪ Declaration of caliphate: 29 June 2014 ▪ Claim of territory in Libya, Egypt, Algeria, Saudi Arabia, Yemen: 13 November 2014 ▪ Claim of territory in South Asia: 29 January 2015[8] ▪ Claim of territory in Nigeria: 12 March 2015[9] ▪ Claim of territory in North Caucasus: 23 June 2015[10]

worldwide.[101] Its adoption of the name Islamic State and its idea of a caliphate have been widely criticised, with the United Nations, various governments, and mainstream Muslim groups vehemently rejecting its statehood.[102]

In Syria, the group conducted ground attacks on both government forces and opposition factions, and by December 2015, it held a large area extending from western Iraq to eastern Syria, containing an estimated 8 to 12 million people,[53][103][54] where it enforced its interpretation of sharia law. ISIL is believed to be operational in 18 countries across the world, including Afghanistan and Pakistan, with "aspiring branches" in Mali, Egypt, Somalia, Bangladesh, Indonesia, and the Philippines.[104][105][106][107] In 2015, ISIL was estimated to have an annual budget of more than US$1 billion and a force of more than 30,000 fighters.[108]

In mid-2014, an international coalition led by the United States intervened against ISIL in Syria and Iraq with a massive airstrike campaign, in addition to supplying advisors, weapons, training, and supplies to ISIL's enemies in the Iraqi Security Forces and Syrian Democratic Forces. This campaign reinvigorated the latter two forces and dealt a huge blow to the nascent Islamist proto-state, killing tens of thousands of ISIL troops[109] and dealing significant damage to their financial and military infrastructure.[110] This was soon followed by a smaller-scale Russian intervention exclusively in Syria, in which ISIL lost thousands more fighters to airstrikes, cruise missile attacks, and other Russian military activities and had its financial base even further degraded.[111] In July 2017, the group lost control of its largest city, Mosul, to the Iraqi army, followed by the loss of its de facto political capital of Raqqa to the Syrian Democratic Forces.[112] Following these major defeats, ISIL continued to lose territory to the various states and other military forces allied against it, until it controlled no meaningful territory by November 2017.[113]

	▪ Recapture of Mosul by Iraqi forces: 20 July 2017 ▪ Capture of Raqqa by SDF forces: 17 October 2017 ▪ Loses all of its territory in Syria: 23 March 2019 ▪ Killing of Baghdadi: October 27, 2019
Ideology	Salafism[11][12][13] Salafi jihadism[13][14] Wahhabism[14][15]
Group(s)	▪ Algerian Province ▪ Caucasus Province ▪ Central Africa Province ▪ East Asia Province ▪ Gaza Province ▪ Greater Sahara Province ▪ Khorasan Province ▪ Libyan Province ▪ Sinai Province ▪ Somalia Province ▪ West Africa Province ▪ Yemen Province
Leaders	▪ **Leader**: Abu Ibrahim al-Hashimi al-Qurashi[16] ▪ **Former leader**: Abu Bakr al-Baghdadi †[17] ▪ **Deputy leader in Iraq**: Abu Fatima al-Jaheishi[18] ▪ **Deputy leader in Syria**: Abu Ali al-Anbari †[19][20] ▪ **Deputy leader in Libya**: Abdel Baqer Al-Najdi[21] ▪ **Military chief**: Abu Saleh al-Obaidi[18] ▪ **Head of the Shura Council**: Abu Arkan al-Ameri[22] ▪ **Chief spokesperson**: Abu Mohammad al-Adnani †[23][24][25][26][27] ▪ **Chief of Syrian military operations**: Abu Omar al-Shishani †[24][28][29][30][31] ▪ **Minister of War**: Gulmurod Khalimov[32] ▪ **Minister of Information**: Wa'il Adil Hasan Salman al-Fayad †[33]

US military officials and simultaneous military analyses reported in December 2017 that the group retained a mere 2 percent of the territory they had previously held.[114] On 10 December 2017, Iraq's Prime Minister, Haider al-Abadi, said that Iraqi forces had driven the last remnants of the Islamic State from the country, three years after the militant group captured about a third of Iraq's territory.[115] By 23 March 2019, ISIL lost one of their last significant territories in the Middle East in the Deir ez-Zor campaign, surrendering their "tent city" and pockets in Al-Baghuz Fawqani to the Syrian Democratic Forces at the end of the Battle of Baghuz Fawqani.[47]

Abu Bakr al-Baghdadi, the leader of ISIL since 2013, later killed himself by detonating a suicide vest during a raid into the rebel-held Idlib province of Syria[116] conducted by U.S. special forces on 27 October 2019.[117][118][119][120] On 31 October, ISIL media announced Abu Ibrahim al-Hashimi al-Qurashi to be Baghdadi's successor.[121]

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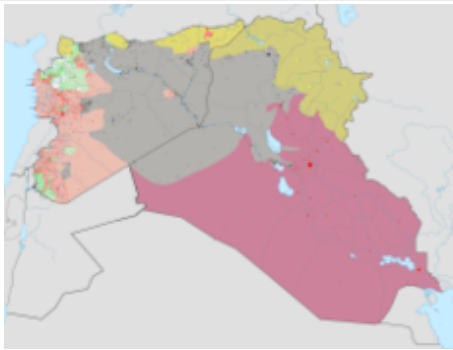
  - Conventional weapons
  - Non-conventional weapons
- Non-combatant recruits
- Women
- Communications
  - Propaganda
  - Traditional media
  - Social media

	▪ **Spokesman**: Abu Hamza al-Qurashi[34]
Headquarters	Baqubah, Iraq (2006–2007) *No central headquarters* (2007–2013) Raqqa, Syria (2013–2017) Mayadin, Syria (June–October 2017)[35][36] Al-Qa'im, Iraq (October–November 2017)[37] Abu Kamal, Syria (November 2017)[38][39] Hajin, Syria (November 2017 – December 2018)[40] Al-Susah, Syria (December 2018 – January 2019)[41][42] Al-Marashidah, Syria (January–February 2019)[43][44][45] Al-Baghuz Fawqani, Syria (February–March 2019)[46][47] Unknown headquarters from March 2019
Area of operations	 ISIL's territory, in grey, at the time of its greatest territorial extent (May 2015). **Map legend** Islamic State of Iraq and the Levant Iraqi government Syrian government Lebanese government Iraqi Kurdistan forces Syrian Kurdistan forces Syrian opposition forces Turkish Armed Forces Tahrir al-Sham (HTS) Hezbollah

Finances
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Name

In April 2013, having expanded into Syria, the group adopted the name *ad-Dawlah al-Islāmiyah fī 'l-ʿIrāq wa-sh-Shām* (الدولة الإسلامية في العراق والشام). As *al-Shām* is a region often compared with the Levant or Greater Syria, the group's name has been variously translated as "Islamic State of Iraq and al-Sham",[122] "Islamic State of Iraq and

	Note: Iraq and Syria contain large desert areas with sparse populations. These areas are mapped as under the control of forces holding roads and towns within them. **Detailed current maps** Detailed map of the Syrian, Iraqi, and Lebanese conflicts Detailed map of the Libyan Civil War Detailed map of the Sinai insurgency Detailed map of the Nigerian insurgency Detailed map of the Yemeni Civil War Detailed map of the Taliban insurgency
Size	**List of combatant numbers** Inside Syria and Iraq: 200,000[48][49] (2015 claim by Iraqi Kurdistan Chief of Staff) 100,000[50][49] (2015 Jihadist claim) 28,600–31,600[51] (2016 Defense Department estimate) 35,000–100,000[52] (State Department estimate) Outside Syria and Iraq: 32,600–57,900 (See Military of ISIL for more detailed estimates.) Estimated total: 61,200–257,900 **Civilian population** In 2015 (near max extent): 8–12 million[53][54]
Allies	See section
Opponent(s)	**State opponents** ▪ Canada ▪ France ▪ Iran ▪ Iraq ▪ Jordan[55] ▪ Lebanon ▪ Libya ▪ Nigeria ▪ Russia ▪ Saudi Arabia ▪ Syria ▪ Turkey

Syria"[123] (both abbreviated as ISIS), or "Islamic State of Iraq and the Levant" (abbreviated as ISIL).[85]

While the use of either one or the other acronym has been the subject of debate,[85][124] the distinction between the two and its relevance has been considered not so great.[85] Of greater relevance is the name Daesh, which is an acronym of ISIL's Arabic name *al-Dawlah al-Islamīyah fī l-ʿIrāq wa-sh-Shām*. *Dāʿish* (داعش), or Daesh. This name has been widely used by ISIL's Arabic-speaking detractors,[125][126] although – and to a certain extent because – it is considered derogatory, as it resembles the Arabic words *Daes* ("one who crushes, or tramples down, something underfoot") and *Dāhis* (loosely translated: "one who sows discord").[86][127] Within areas under its control, ISIL considers use of the name Daesh punishable by flogging[128] or cutting out the tongue.[129]

In late June 2014, the group renamed itself *ad-Dawlah al-Islāmiyah* (lit. Islamic State or *IS*), declaring itself a worldwide caliphate.[99] The name "Islamic State" and the group's claim to be a caliphate have been widely rejected, with the UN, various governments, and mainstream Muslim groups refusing to use the new name.[130][131] The group's declaration of a new caliphate in June 2014 and its adoption of the name "Islamic State" have been criticised and ridiculed by Muslim scholars and rival Islamists both inside and outside the territory it controls.[130][132]

In a speech in September 2014, United States President Barack Obama said that ISIL was neither "Islamic" (on the basis that no religion condones the killing of innocents) nor was it a "state" (in that no government recognises the group as a state),[133] while many object to using the name "Islamic State" owing to the far-reaching religious and political claims to authority which that name implies. The United Nations Security Council,[134] the United States,[133] Canada,[135] Turkey,[136] Australia,[137] Russia,[138] the United

- United Arab Emirates[55]
- United Kingdom
- United States
- Yemen

Many others

Afghanistan[56]
Abkhazia
Albania[55]
Algeria[57]
Armenia
Artsakh
Azerbaijan
Australia[58]
Austria[55]
Bahrain[55]
Bangladesh
Belgium
Benin
Bolivia[59][60]
Bosnia and Herzegovina[55]
Brazil[61]
Cameroon
Canada[62]
Chad
China[63]
DR Congo
Croatia[55]
Czech Republic[55]
Denmark
Egypt
Estonia
Fiji[64]
Finland[55]
Georgia
Germany[65]
Greece[66]
Hungary[55]
India
Indonesia
Ireland[55]
Israel
Italy[67]
Japan[55]
Kazakhstan[68]
North Korea[69]

Kingdom[139] and other countries generally call the group "ISIL", while much of the Arab world uses the Arabic acronym "Dāʿish" (or "Daesh"). France's Foreign Minister Laurent Fabius said "This is a terrorist group and not a state. I do not recommend using the term Islamic State because it blurs the lines between Islam, Muslims, and Islamists. The Arabs call it 'Daesh' and I will be calling them the 'Daesh cutthroats.'"[140] Retired general John Allen, the U.S. envoy appointed to co-ordinate the coalition; U.S. Army Lieutenant General James Terry, head of operations against the group; and Secretary of State John Kerry had all shifted towards use of the term Daesh by December 2014.[141]

Purpose and strategy

Ideology

ISIL is a theocracy, proto-state[142][143][144] and a Salafi or Wahhabi group.[14][145][146] ISIL's ideology represents radical Salafi Islam, a strict, puritanical form of Sunni Islam.[147] Muslim organisations like Islamic Networks Group (ING) in America have argued against this interpretation of Islam.[148] ISIL promotes religious violence, and regards Muslims who do not agree with its interpretations as infidels or apostates.[11] According to Hayder al Khoei, ISIL's philosophy is represented by the symbolism in the Black Standard variant of the legendary battle flag of Muhammad that it has adopted: the flag shows the Seal of Muhammad within a white circle, with the phrase above it, "There is no god but Allah".[149] Such symbolism has been said to point to ISIL's belief that it represents the restoration of the caliphate of early Islam, with all the political, religious and eschatological ramifications that this would imply.[150]

ISIS adheres to global jihadist principles and follows the hard-line ideology of al-Qaeda and many other modern-day jihadist groups,[7][11] which is closely related to Wahhabism.

- South Korea[55]
- Kosovo[55]
- Kyrgyzstan[70]
- Latvia
- Lithuania
- Luxembourg[55]
- Malaysia[71]
- Maldives
- Malta[55]
- Mauritius[72]
- Mexico[55]
- Moldova[55]
- Morocco[55]
- Mozambique
- Netherlands
- New Zealand[55]
- Nicaragua[73]
- Niger
- North Macedonia[55]
- Norway[55]
- Oman[55]
- Pakistan
- Palestine
- Philippines
- Poland[55]
- Portugal[55]
- Qatar[55]
- Romania[55]
- Serbia[55]
- Slovakia[55]
- Slovenia[55]
- Somalia
- South Ossetia
- Spain[74]
- Sri Lanka[75]
- Sweden[55]
- Switzerland[55]
- Taiwan[55]
- Tajikistan[76]
- Thailand
- Tunisia
- Turkmenistan[77]
- Ukraine[55]
- Uzbekistan[78]
- Venezuela[79]

> For their guiding principles, the leaders of the Islamic State ... are open and clear about their almost exclusive commitment to the Wahhabi movement of Sunni Islam. The group circulates images of Wahhabi religious textbooks from Saudi Arabia in the schools it controls. Videos from the group's territory have shown Wahhabi texts plastered on the sides of an official missionary van.
>
> — David D. Kirkpatrick, *The New York Times*[151]

According to *The Economist*, dissidents in the former ISIL capital of Raqqa report that "all 12 of the judges who now run its court system ... are Saudis". Saudi practices also followed by the group include the establishment of religious police to root out "vice" and enforce attendance at salat prayers, the widespread use of capital punishment, and the destruction or re-purposing of any non-Sunni religious buildings.[152] Bernard Haykel has described ISIL leader Abu Bakr al-Baghdadi's creed as "a kind of untamed Wahhabism".[151] Senior Saudi religious leaders have issued statements condemning ISIL[153] and attempting to distance the group from official Saudi religious beliefs.[154]

Western Sahara

Non-state opponents

- Syrian Democratic Forces
- Nineveh Plain Protection Units
- Hezbollah
- Houthis
- Badr Organisation[80]
- Asa'ib Ahl al-Haq[81]
- European Union
- Kata'ib Hezbollah
- Harakat Hezbollah al-Nujaba
- Kata'ib Sayyid al-Shuhada
- Peshmerga
- Kurdistan Communities Union
- Free Syrian Army
- Iraqi Kurdistan
- al-Qaeda
- Ahrar al-Sham
- Al-Nusra Front (Tahrir al-Sham since 2017)
- Libya Shield Force
- Hamas
- Shura Council of Mujahideen in Derna[82]
- Taliban[83]
- Army of Conquest (2015–17)

Full list...

ISIL aims to return to the early days of Islam, rejecting all innovations in the religion, which it believes corrupts its original spirit. It condemns later caliphates and the Ottoman Empire for deviating from what it calls pure Islam, and seeks to revive the original Wahhabi project of the restoration of the caliphate governed by strict Salafist doctrine. Following Salafi-Wahhabi tradition, ISIL condemns the followers of secular law as disbelievers, putting the current Saudi Arabian government in that category.[89]

Salafists such as ISIL believe that only a legitimate authority can undertake the leadership of jihad, and that the first priority over other areas of combat, such as fighting non-Muslim countries, is the purification of Islamic society. For example, ISIL regards the Palestinian Sunni group Hamas as apostates who have no legitimate authority to lead jihad and see fighting Hamas as the first step toward confrontation by ISIL with Israel.[151][155]

Islamic eschatology

One difference between ISIL and other Islamist and jihadist movements, including al-Qaeda, is the group's emphasis on eschatology and apocalypticism – that is, a belief in a final Day of Judgment by God, and specifically, a belief that the arrival of one known as Imam Mahdi is near. ISIL believes that it will defeat the army of "Rome" at the town of Dabiq, in fulfilment of prophecy.[156] Following its interpretation of the Hadith of the Twelve Successors, ISIL also believes that after al-Baghdadi there will be only four more legitimate caliphs.[156]

The noted scholar of militant Islamism Will McCants writes:

> References to the End Times fill Islamic State propaganda. It's a big selling point with foreign fighters, who want to travel to the lands where the final battles of the apocalypse will take place. The civil wars raging in those countries today [Iraq and Syria] lend credibility to the prophecies. The Islamic State has stoked the apocalyptic fire. [...] For Bin Laden's generation, the apocalypse wasn't a great recruiting pitch. Governments in the Middle East two decades ago were more stable, and sectarianism was more subdued. It was better to recruit by calling to arms against corruption and tyranny than against the Antichrist. Today, though, the apocalyptic recruiting pitch makes more sense than before.
>
> — William McCants, *The ISIS Apocalypse: The History, Strategy, and Doomsday Vision of the Islamic State*[157]

Goals

Since at latest 2004, a significant goal of the group has been the foundation of a Sunni Islamic state.[158][159] Specifically, ISIL has sought to establish itself as a caliphate, an Islamic state led by a group of religious authorities under a supreme leader – the caliph – who is believed to be the successor to Prophet Muhammad.[160] In June 2014, ISIL published a document in which it claimed to have traced the lineage of its leader al-Baghdadi back to Muhammad,[160] and upon proclaiming a new caliphate on 29 June, the group appointed al-Baghdadi as its caliph. As caliph, he demands the allegiance of all devout Muslims worldwide, according to Islamic jurisprudence (*fiqh*).[161]

U.S. Army soldier with captured ISIL flag in Iraq, December 2010

ISIL has detailed its goals in its *Dabiq* magazine, saying it will continue to seize land and take over the entire Earth until its:

> Blessed flag...covers all eastern and western extents of the Earth, filling the world with the truth and justice of Islam and putting an end to the falsehood and tyranny of jahiliyyah [state of ignorance], even if America and its coalition despise such.
>
> — 5th edition of *Dabiq*, the Islamic State's English-language magazine[162]

According to German journalist Jürgen Todenhöfer, who spent ten days embedded with ISIL in Mosul, the view he kept hearing was that ISIL wants to "conquer the world", and that all who do not believe in the group's interpretation of the Quran will be killed. Todenhöfer was struck by the ISIL fighters' belief that "all religions who agree with democracy have to die",[163] and by their "incredible enthusiasm" – including enthusiasm for killing "hundreds of millions" of people.[164]

When the caliphate was proclaimed, ISIL stated: "The legality of all emirates, groups, states and organisations becomes null by the expansion of the khilafah's [caliphate's] authority and arrival of its troops to their areas."[160] This was a rejection of the political divisions in Southwestern Asia that were established by the UK and France during World War I in the Sykes–Picot Agreement.[165][166][167]

All non-Muslim areas would be targeted for conquest after the Muslim lands were dealt with, according to the Islamist manual *Management of Savagery*.[168][169][170]

Strategy

The Al-Askari Mosque, one of the holiest sites in Shia Islam, after the first attack by Islamic State of Iraq in 2006

Documents found after the death of Samir Abd Muhammad al-Khlifawi, a former colonel in the intelligence service of the Iraqi Air Force before the US invasion who had been described as "the strategic head" of ISIL, detailed planning for the ISIL takeover of northern Syria which made possible "the group's later advances into Iraq". Al-Khlifawi called for the infiltration of areas to be conquered with spies who would find out "as much as possible about the target towns: Who lived there, who was in charge, which families were religious, which Islamic school of religious jurisprudence they belonged to, how many mosques there were, who the imam was, how many wives and children he had and how old they were". Following this surveillance and espionage would come murder and kidnapping – "the elimination of every person who might have been a potential leader or opponent". In Raqqa, after rebel forces drove out the Assad regime and ISIL infiltrated the town, "first dozens and then hundreds of people disappeared".[171]

Security and intelligence expert Martin Reardon has described ISIL's purpose as being to psychologically "break" those under its control, "[...] so as to ensure their absolute allegiance through fear and intimidation," while generating, "[...]outright hate and vengeance" among its enemies.[172] Jason Burke, a journalist writing on Salafi jihadism, has written that ISIL's goal is to "terrorize, mobilize [and] polarize".[173][174] Its efforts to terrorise are intended to intimidate civilian populations and force governments of the target enemy "to make rash decisions that they otherwise would not choose". It aims to mobilise its supporters by motivating them with, for example, spectacular deadly attacks deep in Western territory (such as the November 2015 Paris attacks), to polarise by driving Muslim populations – particularly in the West – away from their governments, thus increasing the appeal of ISIL's self-proclaimed caliphate among them, and to: "Eliminate neutral parties through either absorption or elimination".[173][175] Journalist Rukmini Maria Callimachi also emphasises ISIL's interest in polarization or in eliminating what it calls the "grey zone" between the black (non-Muslims) and white (ISIL). "The gray is moderate Muslims who are living in the West and are happy and feel engaged in the society here."[176]

A work published online in 2004 entitled *Management of Savagery*[177] (*Idarat at Tawahoush*), described by several media outlets as influential on ISIL[178][179][180] and intended to provide a strategy to create a new Islamic caliphate,[181] recommended a strategy of attack outside its territory in which fighters would, "Diversify and widen the vexation strikes against the Crusader-Zionist enemy in every place in the Islamic world, and even outside of it if possible, so as to disperse the efforts of the alliance of the enemy and thus drain it to the greatest extent possible."[182]

The group has been accused of attempting to "bolster morale" and distract attention from its loss of territory to enemies by staging terror attacks abroad (such as the 2016 Berlin truck attack, the 6 June 2017 attacks on Tehran, the 22 May 2017 bombing in Manchester, UK, and the 3 June 2017 attacks in London that ISIL

claimed credit for).[183]

Organisation

Raqqa in Syria was under ISIL control from 2013 and in 2014 it became the group's *de facto* capital city.[184] On 17 October 2017, following a lengthy battle that saw massive destruction to the city, the Syrian Democratic Forces (SDF) announced the full capture of Raqqa from ISIL.

Leadership and governance

From 2013 to 2019, ISIL was headed and run by Abu Bakr al-Baghdadi, the Islamic State's self-styled Caliph. Before their deaths, he had two deputy leaders, Abu Muslim al-Turkmani for Iraq and Abu Ali al-Anbari (also known as Abu Ala al-Afri)[185] for Syria, both ethnic Turkmen. Advising al-Baghdadi is a cabinet of senior leaders, while its operations in Iraq and Syria are controlled by local 'emirs,' who head semi-autonomous groups which the Islamic State refers to as its provinces.[186][187] Beneath the leaders are councils on finance, leadership, military matters, legal matters (including decisions on executions) foreign fighters' assistance, security, intelligence and media. In addition, a shura council has the task of ensuring that all decisions made by the governors and councils comply with the group's interpretation of sharia.[188] While al-Baghdadi has told followers to "advise me when I err" in sermons, according to observers "any threat, opposition, or even contradiction is instantly eradicated".[189]

Mugshot of Abu Bakr al-Baghdadi by US armed forces while in detention at Camp Bucca in 2004

According to Iraqis, Syrians and analysts who study the group, almost all of ISIL's leaders—including the members of its military and security committees and the majority of its emirs and princes—are former Iraqi military and intelligence officers, specifically former members of Saddam Hussein's Ba'ath government who lost their jobs and pensions in the de-Ba'athification process after that regime was overthrown.[190][191][192][193] The former Chief Strategist in the Office of the Coordinator for Counterterrorism of the US State Department, David Kilcullen, has said that "There undeniably would be no Isis if we had not invaded Iraq."[194] It has been reported that Iraqis and Syrians have been given greater precedence over other nationalities within ISIL because the group needs the loyalties of the local Sunni populations in both Syria and Iraq in order to be sustainable.[195][196] Other reports, however, have indicated that Syrians are at a disadvantage to foreign members, with some native Syrian fighters resenting "favouritism" allegedly shown towards foreigners over pay and accommodation.[197][198]

In August 2016, media reports based on briefings by Western intelligence agencies suggested that ISIL had a multilevel secret service known in Arabic as Emni, established in 2014, that has become a combination of an internal police force and an external operations directorate complete with regional branches. The unit was believed to be under the overall command of ISIL's most senior Syrian operative, spokesman and propaganda chief Abu Mohammad al-Adnani[199][200] until his death by airstrike in late August 2016.[23]

On 27 October 2019 al-Baghdadi was targeted by US military and died after he detonated a suicide vest in Barisha, Idlib, Northwest Syria.[117][118] U.S. President Donald Trump stated in a televised announcement that Baghdadi had in fact raid during the operation and that American forces used support from helicopters, jets and drones through airspace controlled by Russia and Turkey. [201] He said that "Russia treated us great... Iraq was excellent. We really had great cooperation" and Turkey knew they were going in.[202] He thanked Russia, Turkey, Syria, Iraq and the Syrian Kurdish forces for their support.[202] The Turkish

Defence Ministry also confirmed on Sunday that Turkish and U.S. military authorities exchanged and coordinated information ahead of an attack in Syria's Idlib.[203][204] Fahrettin Altun, a senior aide to Turkish President Tayyib Erdogan, also stated, among other things, that "Turkey was proud to help the United States, our NATO ally, bring a notorious terrorist to justice" and that Turkey "will continue to work closely with the United States and others to combat terrorism in all its forms and manifestations."[205] Kremlin spokesman Dmitry Peskov declined to say if the United States had told Russia about the raid in advance but said that its result, if confirmed, represented a serious contribution by the United States to combat terrorism.[206] Russia had previously claimed Baghdadi was killed in May 2019 by their air strike,[207] however Russia TV stated the news of his death on October 27, 2019 is the first to be confirmed.[208]

In September 2019, a statement attributed to ISIL's propaganda arm, the Amaq news agency, claimed that Abdullah Qardash was named as al-Baghdadi's successor.[209][210] Analysts dismissed this statement as a fabrication, and relatives were reported as saying that Qardash died in 2017.[211] Rita Katz, a terrorism analyst and the co-founder of SITE Intelligence, noted that the alleged statement used a different font when compared to other statements and it was never distributed on Amaq or ISIL channels.[212]

On 29 October 2019, Trump stated on social media that al-Baghdadi's "number one replacement" had been killed by American forces, without giving a name.[213] A U.S. official later confirmed that Trump was referring to ISIL spokesman and senior leader Abul-Hasan al-Muhajir,[214] who was killed in a U.S. airstrike in Syria two days earlier.[215] On 31 October, ISIL named Abu Ibrahim al-Hashemi al-Qurayshi as Baghdadi's successor.[216]

Civilians in ISIL-controlled areas

In 2014 *The Wall Street Journal* estimated that eight million people lived in the Islamic State.[217] The United Nations Commission on Human Rights has stated that ISIL "seeks to subjugate civilians under its control and dominate every aspect of their lives through terror, indoctrination, and the provision of services to those who obey".[218] Civilians, as well as the Islamic State itself, have released footage of some of the human rights abuses.[219][220]

Social control of civilians was by imposition of ISIL's reading of sharia law,[221] enforced by morality police forces known as *Al-Hisbah* and the all-women Al-Khanssaa Brigade, a general police force, courts, and other *entities managing recruitment, tribal relations, and education*.[218] *Al-Hisbah* was led by Abu Muhammad al-Jazrawi.[222]

Military

Number of combatants

Estimates of the size of ISIL's military have varied widely, from tens of thousands[224] up to 200,000.[48] In early 2015, journalist Mary Anne Weaver estimated that half of ISIL fighters were foreigners.[225] A UN report estimated a total of 15,000 fighters from over 80 countries were in ISIL's ranks in November 2014.[226] US intelligence estimated an increase to around 20,000 foreign fighters in February 2015,

Country origins of foreign ISIL fighters (500 or more), ICSR estimate, 2018[223]

Country	Fighters
Russia	5,000
Tunisia	4,000
Jordan	3,950
Saudi Arabia	3,244
Turkey	3,000

including 3,400 from the Western world.[227] In September 2015, the CIA estimated that 30,000 foreign fighters had joined ISIL.[228]

According to Abu Hajjar, a former senior leader of ISIL, foreign fighters receive food, petrol and housing, but unlike native Iraqi or Syrian fighters, they do not receive payment in wages.[229] Since 2012, more than 3000 people from the central Asian countries have gone to Syria, Iraq or Afghanistan to join the Islamic State or Jabhat al Nusra.[230]

Uzbekistan	2,500
Morocco	1,699
Tajikistan	1,502
China	1,000
Germany	960
Lebanon	900
Azerbaijan	900
Kyrgyzstan	863
United Kingdom	860
Indonesia	800
Kazakhstan	600
Libya	600
Egypt	500
Turkmenistan	500
Belgium	500

Conventional weapons

ISIL relies mostly on captured weapons with major sources including Saddam Hussein's Iraqi stockpiles from the 2003–11 Iraq insurgency[231] and weapons from government and opposition forces fighting in the Syrian Civil War and during the post-US withdrawal Iraqi insurgency. The captured weapons, including armour, guns, surface-to-air missiles, and even some aircraft, enabled rapid territorial growth and facilitated the capture of additional equipment.[232] For example, ISIL captured US-made TOW anti-tank missiles supplied by the United States and Saudi Arabia to the Free Syrian Army in Syria.[233][234] Ninety percent of the group's weapons ultimately originated in China, Russia or Eastern Europe according to Conflict Armament Research.[235]

Non-conventional weapons

The group uses truck and car bombs, suicide bombers and IEDs, and has used chemical weapons in Iraq and Syria.[236] ISIL captured nuclear materials from Mosul University in July 2014, but is unlikely to be able to convert them into weapons.[237][238] In September 2015 a US official stated that ISIL was manufacturing and using mustard agent in Syria and Iraq, and had an active chemical weapons research team.[239][240] ISIL has also used water as a weapon of war. The group closed the gates of the smaller Nuaimiyah dam in Fallujah in April 2014, flooding the surrounding regions, while cutting the water supply to the Shia-dominated south. Around 12,000 families lost their homes and 200 km^2 of villages and fields were either flooded or dried up. The economy of the region also suffered with destruction of cropland and electricity shortages.[241]

During the Battle of Mosul, commercially available quadcopters and drones were being used by ISIL as surveillance and weapons delivery platforms using improvised cradles to drop grenades and other explosives.[242] One ISIL drone base was struck and destroyed by two Royal Air Force Tornado using two Paveway IV guided bombs.[243]

An ISIL fighter captured by Iraqi Security Forces near Tikrit, 2015

Non-combatant recruits

Although ISIL attracts followers from different parts of the world by promoting the image of holy war, not all of its recruits end up in combatant roles. There have been several cases of new recruits expecting to be *mujahideen* who have

returned from Syria disappointed by the everyday jobs that were assigned to them.

Women

ISIL publishes material directed at women, with media groups encouraging them to play supportive roles within ISIL, such as providing first aid, cooking, nursing and sewing skills, in order to become "good wives of jihad".[244] In 2015, it was estimated that western women made up over 550, or 10%, of ISIL's western foreign fighters.[245]

Until 2016, women were generally confined to a "women's house" upon arrival which they were unallowed to leave. These houses were often small, dirty and infested with vermin and food supply was scarce. There they remained until they either had found a husband, or the husband they had arrived with had completed his training. After being allowed to leave the confinement, women still generally spent most of their days indoors where their lives are devoted to caring for their husbands and the vast majority of women in the conflict area have children. Mothers play an important role passing on ISIL ideology to their children. Widows are encouraged to remarry.[246]

In a document entitled *Women in the Islamic State: Manifesto and Case Study* released by the media wing of ISIL's all-female Al-Khanssaa Brigade, emphasis is given to the paramount importance of marriage and motherhood (as early as nine years old). Women should live a life of "sedentariness", fulfilling her "divine duty of motherhood" at home, with a few exceptions like teachers and doctors.[247][248] Equality for women is opposed, as is education on non-religious subjects, the "worthless worldly sciences".[248]

Communications

Propaganda

ISIL is known for its extensive and effective use of propaganda.[249][250] It uses a version of the Muslim Black Standard flag and developed an emblem which has clear symbolic meaning in the Muslim world.[149]

Traditional media

In November 2006, shortly after the group's rebranding as the "Islamic State of Iraq", it established the Al-Furqan Foundation for Media Production, which produces CDs, DVDs, posters, pamphlets, and web-related propaganda products and official statements.[251] It began to expand its media presence in 2013, with the formation of a second media wing, Al-I'tisam Media Foundation, in March[252][253] and the Ajnad Foundation for Media Production, specialising in nasheeds and audio content, in August.[254] In mid-2014, ISIL established the Al Hayat Media Center, which targets Western audiences and produces material in English, German, Russian and French.[255][256] When ISIL announced its expansion to other countries in November 2014 it established media departments for the new branches, and its media apparatus ensured that the new branches follow the same models it uses in Iraq and Syria.[257] Then FBI Director James Comey said that ISIL's "propaganda is unusually slick," noting that, "They are broadcasting... in something like 23 languages".[258]

In July 2014, al-Hayat began publishing a digital magazine called *Dabiq*, in a number of different languages including English.[259] According to the magazine, its name is taken from the town of Dabiq in northern Syria, which is mentioned in a hadith about Armageddon.[260] Al-Hayat also began publishing other digital

magazines, including the Turkish language *Konstantiniyye*, the Ottoman word for Istanbul,[261][262] and the French language *Dar al-Islam*.[263] By late 2016, these magazines had apparently all been discontinued, with Al-Hayat's material being consolidated into a new magazine called *Rumiyah* (Arabic for Rome).[264]

The group also runs a radio network called Al-Bayan, which airs bulletins in Arabic, Russian and English and provides coverage of its activities in Iraq, Syria and Libya.[265]

Social media

ISIL's use of social media has been described by one expert as "probably more sophisticated than [that of] most US companies".[249][266] It regularly uses social media, particularly Twitter, to distribute its messages.[266][267] The group uses the encrypted instant messaging service Telegram to disseminate images, videos and updates.[268]

The group is known for releasing videos and photographs of executions of prisoners, whether beheadings, shootings, caged prisoners being burnt alive or submerged gradually until drowned.[269] Journalist Abdel Bari Atwan described ISIL's media content as part of a "systematically applied policy". The escalating violence of its killings "guarantees" the attention of the media and public.[189]

Along with images of brutality, ISIL presents itself as "an emotionally attractive place where people 'belong', where everyone is a 'brother' or 'sister'". The "most potent psychological pitch" of ISIL media is the promise of heavenly reward to dead jihadist fighters. Frequently posted in their media are dead jihadists' smiling faces, the ISIL 'salute' of a 'right-hand index finger pointing heavenward', and testimonies of happy widows.[189] ISIL has also attempted to present a more "rational argument" in a series of videos hosted by the kidnapped journalist John Cantlie. In one video, various current and former US officials were quoted, such as the then US President Barack Obama and former CIA Officer Michael Scheuer.[270]

It has encouraged sympathisers to initiate vehicle-ramming and attacks worldwide.[271]

Finances

According to a 2015 study by the Financial Action Task Force, ISIL's five primary sources of revenue are as follows (listed in order of significance):

- proceeds from the occupation of territory (including control of banks, petroleum reservoirs, taxation, extortion, and robbery of economic assets)
- kidnapping for ransom[272]
- donations from Saudi Arabia and Gulf states, often disguised as meant for "humanitarian charity"
- material support provided by foreign fighters
- fundraising through modern communication networks[273]

Since 2012, ISIL has produced annual reports giving numerical information on its operations, somewhat in the style of corporate reports, seemingly in a bid to encourage potential donors.[249][274]

In 2014, the RAND Corporation analysed ISIL's funding sources from documents captured between 2005 and 2010.[275] It found that outside donations amounted to only 5% of the group's operating budgets,[275] and that cells inside Iraq were required to send up to 20% of the income generated from kidnapping, extortion rackets and other activities to the next level of the group's leadership, which would then redistribute the funds to provincial or local cells that were in difficulties or needed money to conduct

attacks.[275] In 2016, RAND estimated that ISIL finances from its largest source of income — oil revenues and the taxes it extracts from people under its control — had fallen from about $1.9 billion in 2014 to $870 million.[276]

In mid-2014, the Iraqi National Intelligence Service obtained information that ISIL had assets worth US$2 billion,[277] making it the richest jihadist group in the world.[278] About three-quarters of this sum was said to looted from Mosul's central bank and commercial banks in the city.[279][280] However, doubt was later cast on whether ISIL was able to retrieve anywhere near that sum from the central bank,[281] and even on whether the looting had actually occurred.[282]

Monetary system

ISIL attempted to create a modern gold dinar by minting gold, silver, and copper coins, based on the coinage used by the Umayyad Caliphate in the 7th century.[283][284][285][286] Despite a propaganda push for the currency, adoption appeared to have been minimal and its internal economy is effectively dollarized, even with regards to its own fines.[287]

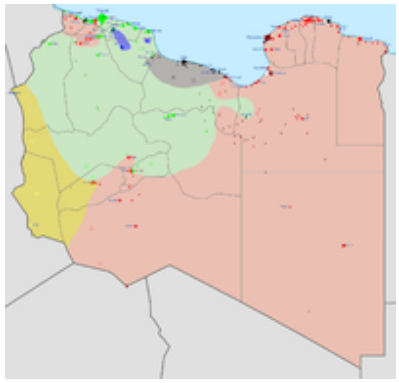
History

The group was founded in 1999 by Jordanian Salafi jihadist Abu Musab al-Zarqawi under the name *Jamāʿat al-Tawḥīd wa-al-Jihād* (lit. "The Organisation of Monotheism and Jihad").[84] In a letter published by the Coalition in February 2004, Zarqawi wrote that jihadis should use bombings to start an open sectarian war so that Sunnis from the Islamic world would mobilize against assassinations carried out by Shia, specifically the Badr Brigade, against Ba'athists and Sunnis.[288]

The UN headquarters building in Baghdad after the Canal Hotel bombing, on 22 August 2003

Territorial control and claims

As a self-proclaimed worldwide caliphate, ISIL claims religious, political and military authority over all Muslims worldwide,[101] and that "the legality of all emirates, groups, states, and organisations, becomes null by the expansion of the khilāfah's [caliphate's] authority and arrival of its troops to their areas".[160]



Military situation in Libya in early 2016:
● Ansar al-Sharia ● ISIL

In Iraq and Syria, ISIL used many of those countries' existing governorate boundaries to subdivide territory it conquered and claimed; it called these divisions wilayah or provinces.[289] By June 2015, ISIL had also established official "provinces" in Libya, Egypt (Sinai Peninsula), Saudi Arabia, Yemen, Algeria, Afghanistan, Pakistan, Nigeria and the North Caucasus.[290] ISIL received pledges of allegiance and publish media releases from groups in countries like Somalia,[291] Bangladesh[292] and the Philippines,[293] but it has not announced any further official branches, instead identifying new affiliates as simply "soldiers of the caliphate".[294]

By March 2019, ISIL had lost most of its territory in its former core areas in Syria and Iraq, and was reduced to a desert pocket as well as insurgent cells.[295]

ISIL's capital Raqqa suffered extensive damage during the battle of Raqqa in June–October 2017

International reaction

Classification as a terrorist organisation

Many countries and international bodies have officially designated ISIL as a terrorist organisation.

International criticism

The group has attracted widespread criticism internationally for its extremism, from governments and international bodies such as the United Nations and Amnesty International. On 24 September 2014, United Nations Secretary-General Ban Ki-Moon stated: "As Muslim leaders around the world have said, groups like ISIL – or Da'ish – have nothing to do with Islam, and they certainly do not represent a state. They should more fittingly be called the 'Un-Islamic Non-State'."[296] ISIL has been classified a terrorist organisation by the United Nations, the European Union and its member states, the United States, Russia, India, Turkey, Saudi Arabia and many other countries (see § Classification). Over 60 countries are directly or indirectly waging war against ISIL (see § Countries and groups at war with ISIL). The group was described as a cult in a Huffington Post column by notable cult authority Steven Hassan.[297]

Islamic criticism

The group's declaration of a caliphate has been criticised and its legitimacy has been disputed by Middle Eastern governments, by Sunni Muslim theologians and historians as well as other jihadist groups.[298]

Religious leaders and organisations

Around the world, Islamic religious leaders have overwhelmingly condemned ISIL's ideology and actions, arguing that the group has strayed from the path of true Islam and that its actions do not reflect the religion's real teachings or virtues.[299]

Extremism within Islam goes back to the 7th century, to the Khawarijes. From their essentially political position, the Kharijites developed extreme doctrines which set them apart from both mainstream Sunni and Shia Muslims. They were particularly noted for adopting a radical approach to takfir, whereby they declared other Muslims to be unbelievers and therefore deemed worthy of death.[300][301][302][303] Other scholars have also described the group not as Sunnis, but as Khawarij.[301][304] Sunni critics, including Salafi and jihadist muftis such as Adnan al-Aroor and Abu Basir al-Tartusi, say that ISIL and related terrorist groups are not Sunnis, but are instead modern-day Kharijites (Muslims who have stepped outside the mainstream of Islam) serving an imperial anti-Islamic agenda.[305]

In late August 2014, the Grand Mufti of Saudi Arabia, Abdul-Aziz ibn Abdullah Al ash-Sheikh, condemned ISIL and al-Qaeda saying, "Extremist and militant ideas and terrorism which spread decay on Earth, destroying human civilization, are not in any way part of Islam, but are enemy number one of Islam, and Muslims are their first victims".[306] In late September 2014, 126 Sunni imams and Islamic scholars—

primarily Sufi[307]—from around the Muslim world signed an open letter to the Islamic State's leader al-Baghdadi, explicitly rejecting and refuting his group's interpretations of Islamic scriptures, the Quran and hadith, which it used in order to justify its actions.[308][309] "[You] have misinterpreted Islam into a religion of harshness, brutality, torture and murder ... this is a great wrong and an offence to Islam, to Muslims and to the entire world", the letter states.[310] It rebukes the Islamic State for its killing of prisoners, describing the killings as "heinous war crimes" and its persecution of the Yazidis of Iraq as "abominable". Referring to the "self-described 'Islamic State'", the letter censures the group for carrying out killings and acts of brutality under the guise of jihad—holy struggle—saying that its "sacrifice" without legitimate cause, goals and intention "is not jihad at all, but rather, warmongering and criminality".[310][311] It also accuses the group of instigating fitna—sedition—by instituting slavery under its rule in contravention of the anti-slavery consensus of the Islamic scholarly community.[310]

Kurdish demonstration against ISIL in Vienna, Austria, 10 October 2014

The current Grand Imam of al-Azhar and former president of al-Azhar University, Ahmed el-Tayeb, has strongly condemned the Islamic State, stating that it is acting "under the guise of this holy religion and have given themselves the name 'Islamic State' in an attempt to export their false Islam".[312][313] Citing the Quran, he stated: "The punishment for those who wage war against God and his Prophet and who strive to sow corruption on earth is death, crucifixion, the severing of hands and feet on opposite sides or banishment from the land. This is the disgrace for them in this world and in the hereafter they will receive grievous torment." Although el-Tayeb has been criticised for not expressly stating that the Islamic State is heretical,[314][315] the Ash'ari school of Islamic theology, to which el-Tayeb belongs, does not allow calling a person who follows the shahada an apostate.[314] El-Tayeb has strongly come out against the practice of takfirism (declaring a Muslim an apostate) which is used by the Islamic State to "judge and accuse anyone who doesn't tow their line with apostasy and outside the realm of the faith" declaring "Jihad on peaceful Muslims" using "flawed interpretations of some Qur'anic texts, the prophet's Sunna, and the Imams' views believing incorrectly, that they are leaders of Muslim armies fighting infidel peoples, in unbelieving lands".[316]

In late December 2015, nearly 70,000 Indian Muslim clerics associated with the Indian Barelvi movement issued a fatwa condemning ISIL and similar organisations, saying they are "not Islamic organisations". Approximately 1.5 million Sunni Muslim followers of this movement have formally decried violent extremists.[317][318][319]

Mehdi Hasan, a political journalist in the UK, said in the *New Statesman*,

> Whether Sunni or Shia, Salafi or Sufi, conservative or liberal, Muslims – and Muslim leaders – have almost unanimously condemned and denounced ISIL not merely as un-Islamic but actively anti-Islamic.[299]

Hassan Hassan, an analyst at the Delma Institute, wrote in *The Guardian* that because the Islamic State "bases its teachings on religious texts that mainstream Muslim clerics do not want to deal with head on, new recruits leave the camp feeling that they have stumbled on the true message of Islam".[145]

Theologian and Qatar-based TV broadcaster Yusuf al-Qaradawi stated: "[The] declaration issued by the Islamic State is void under sharia and has dangerous consequences for the Sunnis in Iraq and for the revolt in Syria", adding that the title of caliph can "only be given by the entire Muslim nation", not by a single

group.[320] He also stated on his official website "United Arab Emirates (UAE) and the leaders of Daesh (ISIS/ISIL) terrorist group are from one species and they are two sides of the same coin".[321] In a similar vein, the Syrian Islamic scholar Muhammad al-Yaqoubi says, "[t]he followers of ISIS do not want to adhere to Islamic law but rather they want to twist Islamic law to conform to their fantasies. To this end, they pick and choose the evidences that corroborate their misguidance, despite being weak or abrogated."[322]

Academics Robyn Creswell and Bernard Haykel of *The New Yorker* have criticized ISIL's execution of Muslims for breach of traditional *sharia* law while violating it simultaneously themselves (encouraging women to emigrate to its territory, travelling without a *Wali*—male guardian—and in violation of his wishes).[323] as well as its love of archaic imagery (horsemen and swords) while engaging in *bid'ah* (religious innovation) in establishing female religious police (known as Al-Khansaa Brigade).[324]

Two days after the beheading of Hervé Gourdel, hundreds of Muslims gathered in the Grand Mosque of Paris to show solidarity against the beheading. The protest was led by the leader of the French Council of the Muslim Faith, Dalil Boubakeur, and was joined by thousands of other Muslims around the country under the slogan "Not in my name".[325][326] French president François Hollande said Gourdel's beheading was "cowardly" and "cruel", and confirmed that airstrikes would continue against ISIL in Iraq. Hollande also called for three days of national mourning, with flags flown at half-mast throughout the country and said that security would be increased throughout Paris.[325]

Other jihadist groups

According to *The New York Times*, "All of the most influential jihadist theorists are criticising the Islamic State as deviant, calling its self-proclaimed caliphate null and void" and they have denounced it for its beheadings of journalists and aid workers.[151] ISIL is widely denounced by a broad range of Islamic clerics, including Saudi and al-Qaeda-oriented clerics.[14][151] Muhammad al-Yaqoubi states, "It is enough of a proof of the extreme ideology of ISIS that the top leaders of Salafi-Jihadism have disclaimed it."[327] Other critics of ISIL's brand of Sunni Islam include Salafists who previously publicly supported jihadist groups such as al-Qaeda: for example, the Saudi government official Saleh Al-Fawzan, known for his extremist views, who claims that ISIL is a creation of "Zionists, Crusaders and Safavids", and the Jordanian-Palestinian writer Abu Muhammad al-Maqdisi, the former spiritual mentor to Abu Musab al-Zarqawi, who was released from prison in Jordan in June 2014 and accused ISIL of driving a wedge between Muslims.[305]

An Islamic Front sharia court judge in Aleppo, Mohamed Najeeb Bannan, stated: "The legal reference is the Islamic Sharia. The cases are different, from robberies to drug use, to moral crimes. It's our duty to look at any crime that comes to us... After the regime has fallen, we believe that the Muslim majority in Syria will ask for an Islamic state. Of course, it's very important to point out that some say the Islamic Sharia will cut off people's hands and heads, but it only applies to criminals. And to start off by killing, crucifying etc. That is not correct at all." In response to being asked what the difference between the Islamic Front's and ISIL's version of sharia would be, he said, "One of their mistakes is before the regime has fallen, and before they've established what in Sharia is called Tamkeen [having a stable state], they started applying Sharia, thinking God gave them permission to control the land and establish a Caliphate. This goes against the beliefs of religious scholars around the world. This is what [IS] did wrong. This is going to cause a lot of trouble. Anyone who opposes [IS] will be considered against Sharia and will be severely punished."[328][329]

Al-Qaeda and al-Nusra have been trying to take advantage of ISIL's rise, by attempting to present themselves as "moderate" compared to "extremist" ISIL, although it has the same aim of establishing sharia and a caliphate but doing so in a more gradual manner.[330][331][332][333][334] Al-Nusra has criticised the way in which ISIL fully and immediately institutes sharia in the areas that fall under its control, since it alienates people too much. It supports the gradual, slower approach favoured by al-Qaeda, preparing society to accept sharia and indoctrinating people through education before implementing the hudud aspects in sharia, which they believe supports punishments such as throwing homosexuals from the top of buildings, chopping limbs off, and public stoning.[162] Al-Nusra and ISIL are both hostile towards the Druze. However, while al-Nusra has typically destroyed Druze shrines and pressured them to convert to Sunni Islam, ISIL regards the entire Druze community as a valid target for violence, as it does the Yazidis.[335]

Ayman al-Zawahiri, the leader of al-Qaeda, has called for consultation (shura) within the "prophetic method" to be used when establishing the caliphate, criticising al-Baghdadi for not following the required steps. Al-Zawahiri has called upon ISIL members to close ranks and join al-Qaeda in fighting against Assad, the Shia, Russia, Europe, and America and to stop the infighting between jihadist groups. He called upon jihadists to establish Islamic entities in Egypt and the Levant, slowly implementing sharia before establishing a caliphate, and has called for violent assaults against America and the West.[336]

The Jaysh al-Islam group within the Islamic Front criticised ISIL, saying: "They killed the people of Islam and leave the idol worshippers ... They use the verses talking about the disbelievers and implement it on the Muslims".[337] The main criticism of defectors from ISIL has been that the group is fighting and killing other Sunni Muslims,[338] as opposed to just non-Sunnis being brutalised.[339][340] In one case, a supposed defector from ISIL executed two activists of a Syrian opposition group in Turkey who had sheltered them.[341]

Operations Targeting Terrorists

On 17 November 2019, the Iraqi security forces killed two Daesh terrorists in the northern Kirkuk province in an operation, which targeted terrorists in the rural area of Riyadh town.[342]

Other commentaries

Scholar Ian Almond criticised the media commentators, the lack of balance in reporting, and the "way we are learning to talk about ISIS." While there was talk about 'radical evil' and 'radical Islam', Almond found it striking because "some of the most revered and oft-quoted figures in our Western political tradition have been capable of the most vicious acts of savagery – and yet all we ever hear about is how much the Middle East has to learn from us." Almond goes on to cite how Winston Churchill "wanted to gas women and children", how Ronald Reagan's Central American policies "disembowlled more children than ISIS," how President Barack Obama's "planes and drones have dropped bombs on as many schoolchildren as ISIS," how former secretary of state Madeleine Albright commented on the deaths of Iraqi children killed by sanctions, how Henry Kissinger and Margaret Thatcher "assisted in the torture and disappearance of thousands of Chilean students and labour activitists... For anyone familiar with the history of both U.S. and European torture and murder over the past 150 years, it might not be all that hyperbolic to say that in ISIS, what we see more than anything else is a more expansive, explicit version of our own cruelties. In bombing ISIS and its would-be imperialism, we are really bombing a version of ourselves."[343]

Author and commentator Tom Engelhardt attributed the rise of ISIL and the destruction that followed to what he dubbed as America's drive to establish its own caliphate in the region.[344]

A leader article in the New Scientist magazine contextualised ISIL within the nation state construct. Although the group is described as medieval in the pejorative sense, "it is also hyper-modern, interested in few of the trappings of a conventional state apart from its own brutal brand of law enforcement. In fact, it is more of a network than a nation, having made canny use of social media to exert influence far beyond its geographical base."[345]

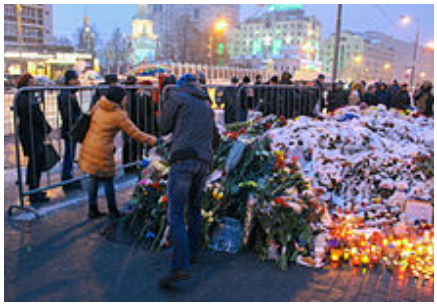
Designation as a terrorist organisation

Organisation	Date	Body	References
Multinational organisations			
United Nations	18 October 2004 (as al-Qaeda in Iraq) 30 May 2013 (after separation from al-Qaeda)	United Nations Security Council	[346][347][348]
European Union	2004	EU Council (via adoption of UN al-Qaeda Sanctions List)	[349]
Nations			
United Kingdom	March 2001 (as part of al-Qaeda) 20 June 2014 (after separation from al-Qaeda)	Home Office	[350]
United States	17 December 2004 (as al-Qaeda in Iraq)	United States Department of State	[351]
Australia	2 March 2005 (as al-Qaeda in Iraq) 14 December 2013 (after separation from al-Qaeda)	Attorney-General for Australia	[352]
Canada	20 August 2012	Parliament of Canada	[353]
Turkey	30 October 2013	Grand National Assembly of Turkey	[354][355]
Saudi Arabia	7 March 2014	Royal decree of the King of Saudi Arabia	[356]
Indonesia	1 August 2014	Counter-Terrorism National Agency (BNPT)	[357]
United Arab Emirates	20 August 2014	United Arab Emirates Cabinet	[358]
Malaysia	24 September 2014	Ministry of Foreign Affairs	[359]
Switzerland	8 October 2014	Swiss Federal Council	[360]
Egypt	30 November 2014	The Cairo Court for Urgent Matters	[361][362]
India	16 December 2014	Ministry of Home Affairs	[363][364]
Russian Federation	29 December 2014	Supreme Court of Russia	[365]
Kyrgyzstan	25 March 2015	Kyrgyz State Committee of National Security	[366]
Syria			[367]
Jordan			[368]
Iran			[369][370][371][372]
Iraq			[373][374]
Trinidad and Tobago			[375]
Pakistan	29 August 2015	Ministry of Interior	[376]
Japan		Public Security Intelligence Agency	[377]
Republic of China (Taiwan)	26 November 2015	National Security Bureau	[378]
People's		Ministry of Public Security	[379]

Republic of China			
Venezuela	4 September 2019	National Assembly of Venezuela	[79]

The United Nations Security Council in its Resolution 1267 (1999) described Osama bin Laden and his al-Qaeda associates as operators of a network of terrorist training camps.[380] The UN's Al-Qaida Sanctions Committee first listed ISIL in its Sanctions List under the name "Al-Qaida in Iraq" on 18 October 2004, as an entity/group associated with al-Qaeda. On 2 June 2014, the group was added to its listing under the name "Islamic State in Iraq and the Levant". The European Union adopted the UN Sanctions List in 2002.[349]

Many world leaders and government spokespeople have called ISIL a terrorist group or banned it, without their countries having formally designated it as such. The following are examples:



People lay flowers outside the French embassy in Moscow in memory of the victims of the November 2015 Paris attacks.

The Government of Germany banned ISIL in September 2014. Activities banned include donations to the group, recruiting fighters, holding ISIL meetings and distributing its propaganda, flying ISIL flags,[381] wearing ISIL symbols and all ISIL activities. "The terror organisation Islamic State is a threat to public safety in Germany as well", said German politician Thomas de Maizière. He added, "Today's ban is directed solely against terrorists who abuse religion for their criminal goals."[382] Being a member of ISIL is also illegal in accordance with § 129a and § 129b of the German criminal code.[383]

In October 2014, Switzerland banned ISIL's activities in the country, including propaganda and financial support of the fighters, with prison sentences as potential penalties.[384]

In mid-December 2014, India banned ISIL after the arrest of an operator of a pro-ISIL Twitter account.[385]

Pakistan designated ISIL as a banned organisation in late August 2015, under which all elements expressing sympathy for the group would be blacklisted and sanctioned.[376]

Media sources worldwide have described ISIL as a terrorist organisation.[85][192][249][221][357][386]

Militia, cult, territorial authority and other classifications

By 2014, ISIL was increasingly being viewed as a militia in addition to a terrorist group and a cult.[387] As major Iraqi cities fell to ISIL in June 2014, Jessica Lewis, a former US Army intelligence officer at the Institute for the Study of War, described ISIL at that time as

> not a terrorism problem anymore, [but rather] an army on the move in Iraq and Syria, and they are taking terrain. They have shadow governments in and around Baghdad, and they have an aspirational goal to govern. I don't know whether they want to control Baghdad, or if they want to destroy the functions of the Iraqi state, but either way the outcome will be disastrous for Iraq.[387]

Lewis has called ISIL

> an advanced military leadership. They have incredible command and control and they have a sophisticated reporting mechanism from the field that can relay tactics and directives up and down the line. They are well-financed, and they have big sources of manpower, not just the foreign fighters, but also prisoner escapees.[387]

Supporters of the Turkish Labour Party protesting in London following the 2015 Ankara bombings

Former US Defense Secretary Chuck Hagel saw an "imminent threat to every interest we have", but former top counter-terrorism adviser Daniel Benjamin derided such talk as a "farce" that panics the public.[388]

Former British Foreign Secretary David Miliband concluded that the 2003 invasion of Iraq caused the creation of ISIL.[389]

Writing for *The Guardian*, Pankaj Mishra rejects the idea that the group is a resurgence of medieval Islam, saying instead:

> In actuality, Isis is the canniest of all traders in the flourishing international economy of disaffection: the most resourceful among all those who offer the security of collective identity to isolated and fearful individuals. It promises, along with others who retail racial, national and religious supremacy, to release the anxiety and frustrations of the private life into the violence of the global.[390]

On 28 January 2017, President Donald Trump issued a National Security Presidential Memorandum which called for a comprehensive plan to destroy ISIL to be formulated by the Defense Department within 30 days.[391]

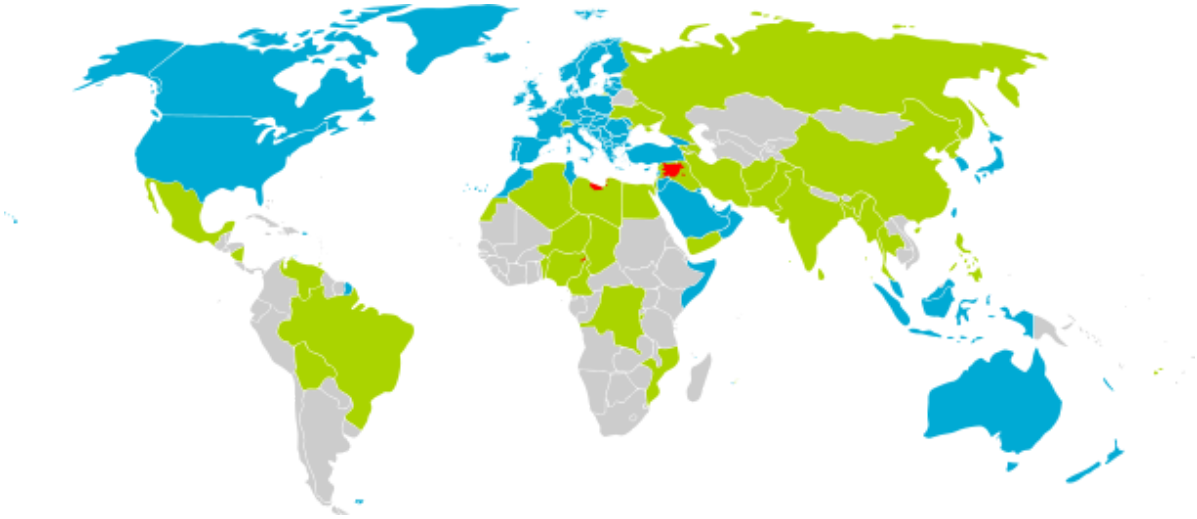
Supporters

According to a June 2015 Reuters report that cited "jihadist ideologues" as a source, 90% of ISIL's fighters in Iraq were Iraqi, and 70% of its fighters in Syria were Syrian. The article stated that the group had 40,000 fighters and 60,000 supporters across its two primary strongholds in Iraq and Syria.[50] According to scholar Fawaz Gerges writing in *ISIS: A History*, some "30 percent of the senior figures" in ISIL's military command were former army and police officers from the disbanded Iraqi security forces, turned towards Sunni Islamism and drawn to ISIL by the US de-Ba'athification policy following the US invasion of Iraq.[189]

According to a poll by Pew Research Center, Muslim populations of various countries have overwhelmingly negative views of ISIL with Lebanon having the most unfavorable views.[392][393] In most of these countries, concerns about Islamic extremism have been growing.[394]

There are at least 10,000 ISIL prisoners and more than 100,000 ISIL family members and other displaced persons in several camps across the Kurdish areas in Syria.[395][396]

Countries and groups at war with ISIL

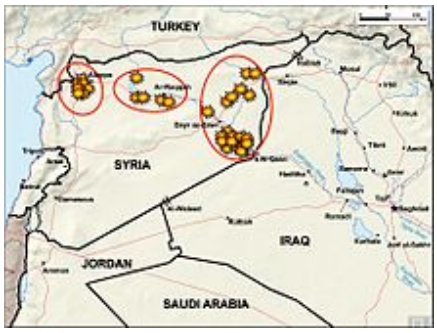


A map of all state-based opponents of ISIL
- US Combined Joint Task Force – Operation Inherent Resolve
- Russia and other state-based opponents
- Territories held by ISIL at its late 2015 peak

ISIL's claims to territory have brought it into armed conflict with many governments, militias and other armed groups. International rejection of ISIL as a terrorist entity and rejection of its claim to even exist have placed it in conflict with countries around the world.

Global Coalition to Counter the Islamic State of Iraq and the Levant

The Global Coalition to Counter the Islamic State of Iraq and the Levant (ISIL), also referred to as the Counter-ISIL Coalition or Counter-DAESH Coalition,[397] is a US-led group of nations and non-state actors that have committed to "work together under a common, multifaceted, and long-term strategy to degrade and defeat ISIL/Daesh". According to a joint statement issued by 59 national governments and the European Union on 3 December 2014, participants in the Counter-ISIL Coalition are focused on multiple lines of effort:[398]



Airstrikes in Syria by 24 September 2014

1. Supporting military operations, capacity building, and training;
2. Stopping the flow of foreign terrorist fighters;
3. Cutting off ISIL/Daesh's access to financing and funding;
4. Addressing associated humanitarian relief and crises; and
5. Exposing ISIL/Daesh's true nature (ideological delegitimisation).

Operation Inherent Resolve is the operational name given by the US to military operations against ISIL and Syrian al-Qaeda affiliates. Combined Joint Task Force – Operation Inherent Resolve (CJTF–OIR) is co-ordinating the military portion of the response. The Arab League, European Union, NATO, and GCC are part of the Counter-ISIL Coalition:[398] According to the Pentagon, by December 2017 over 80,000 ISIL fighters had been killed in Iraq and Syria by CJTF-OIR airstrikes.[109] By then the coalition had flown over 170,000 sorties,[399] 75-80% of combat sorties were conducted by the military of the United States, with the other 20-25% by Australia, Canada, Denmark, France, Jordan, Belgium, the Netherlands, Saudi Arabia, Turkey, the United Arab Emirates, and the United Kingdom.[400] According to the UK-based monitoring group *Airwars*, the air strikes and artillery of US-led coalition killed as many as 6,000 civilians in Iraq and Syria by the end of 2017.[401][402]

Lebanon, which the U.S. considers part of the Global Coalition, fought off several incursions by ISIL, with the largest engagements taking place from June 2014 to August 2017, when several thousand ISIL fighters invaded from Syria and occupied Lebanese territory. The U.S. and U.K.-backed Lebanese Army succeeded in repulsing this invasion, killing or capturing over 1,200 ISIL fighters in the process.[403][404][405]

On December 21, 2019, over 33 Islamist militants were killed in Mali by French forces using attack helicopters, drones and ground troops, alongside the border with Mauritania where an Al-Qaeda-linked group operates.[406]

Other state opponents not part of the Counter-ISIL Coalition

Iran[407] – military advisors, training, ground troops, and air power in Iraq and Syria, beside Iranian borders (*see Iranian intervention in Iraq*)

Liberation of Palmyra by the Russia–Syria–Iran–Iraq coalition in March 2016

Russia[408][409] – arms supplier to Iraqi and Syrian governments. In June 2014, the Iraqi army received Russian Sukhoi Su-25 and Sukhoi Su-30 fighter aircraft to combat the ISIL.[410] Security operations within state borders in 2015.[411][412] Airstrikes in Syria (see Russian military intervention in the Syrian Civil War).[413][414][415]

Azerbaijan[416][417] – security operations within state borders

Pakistan – Military deployment over Saudi Arabia-Iraq border. Arresting ISIL figures in Pakistan.[418][419][420]

Russian Sukhoi Su-34 in Syria

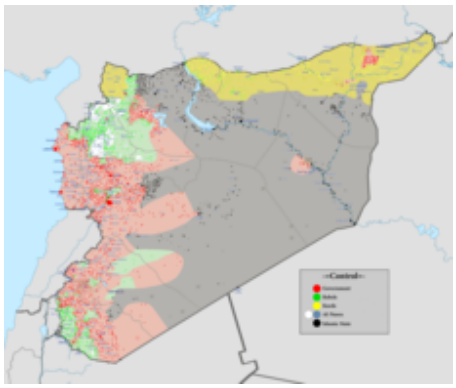
Yemen (Supreme Political Council)[421]

Other non-state opponents

- al-Qaeda[84]
- al-Nusra Front[422]—with localised truces and co-operation at times
- al-Qaeda in the Arabian Peninsula[423]
- al-Qaeda in the Islamic Maghreb[424]
- Al-Shabaab[425]
- Taliban[426][427]
- Hamas[428]
- Hezbollah[429]
- Houthis[430]
- Kurdistan Workers' Party—ground troops in Iraqi Kurdistan and in Syrian Kurdistan[431]
- Syrian Democratic Forces
- Nineveh Plain Protection Units – an Assyrian Christian militia in the Nineveh Plains of Iraq and Syria[432]

Al-Qaeda

Al-Nusra Front is a branch of al-Qaeda operating in Syria. Al-Nusra has launched many attacks and bombings, mostly against targets affiliated with or supportive of the Syrian government.[433] There have been media reports that many of al-Nusra's foreign fighters have left to join al-Baghdadi's ISIL.[434]



Military situation in Syria in November 2015

In February 2014, after continued tensions, al-Qaeda publicly disavowed any relations with ISIL.[435] However, ISIL and al-Nusra Front still cooperate with each other occasionally when they fight against the Syrian government.[436][437][438]

> The two groups [ISIL and al-Nusra] share a nihilistic worldview, a loathing for modernity, and for the West. They subscribe to the same perverted interpretations of Islam. Other common traits include a penchant for suicide attacks, and sophisticated exploitation of the internet and social media. Like ISIL, several Al Qaeda franchises are interested in taking and holding territory; AQAP has been much less successful at it. The main differences between Al Qaeda and ISIL are largely political—and personal. Over the past decade, Al Qaeda has twice embraced ISIL (and its previous manifestations) as brothers-in-arms.
>
> — "ISIL and Al Qaeda: Terror's frenemies", *Quartz*[439]

On 10 September 2015, an audio message was released by al-Qaeda's leader Ayman al-Zawahiri criticising ISIL's self-proclaimed caliphate and accusing it of "sedition". This was described by some media outlets as a "declaration of war".[440] However, although al-Zawahiri denied ISIL's legitimacy, he suggested that there was still room for cooperation against common enemies, and said that if he were in Iraq, he would fight alongside ISIL.[441]

Human rights abuse and war crime findings

In July 2014, the BBC reported the United Nations' chief investigator as stating: "Fighters from the Islamic State in Iraq and the Levant (ISIL) may be added to a list of war crimes suspects in Syria."[442] By June 2014, according to United Nations reports, ISIL had killed hundreds of prisoners of war[443] and over 1,000 civilians.

In November 2014, the UN Commission of Inquiry on Syria said that ISIL was committing crimes against humanity.[444][96] A report by Human Rights Watch in November 2014 accused ISIL groups in control of Derna, Libya of war crimes and human rights abuses and of terrorising residents. Human Rights Watch documented three apparent summary executions and at least ten public floggings by the Islamic Youth Shura Council, which joined ISIL in November. It also documented the beheading of three Derna residents and dozens of seemingly politically motivated assassinations of judges, public officials, members of the

security forces and others. Sarah Leah Watson, Director of HRW Middle East and North Africa, said: "Commanders should understand that they may face domestic or international prosecution for the grave rights abuses their forces are committing."[445]

Speaking of ISIL's methods, the United Nations Commission on Human Rights has stated that the group "seeks to subjugate civilians under its control and dominate every aspect of their lives through terror, indoctrination, and the provision of services to those who obey".[218]

See also

- Islamic State of Iraq
- Islamic State of Iraq and the Levant – Khorasan Province
- Violent extremism
- List of armed groups in the Iraqi Civil War
- List of armed groups in the Syrian Civil War
- List of wars and battles involving ISIL
- Operation Inherent Resolve
- Islamic Military Alliance
- Rape during the Syrian Civil War
- *Damascus Time*
- It's On U

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